Loss Analysis: Buffalo Rock Company 02-2026

Buffalo Rock puts Novara deal on pause; "just a bad time" with concerns about internal bandwidth; could revisit in 2027

KEY DECISION FACTORS

- Concerned about ability to successfully launch Novara across Buffalo Rock based on internal team bandwidth
- Incumbent solution for incident reporting (Safety Reports by Align Technologies) "not the best" overall, but good enough for now
- Really liked Novara solution; met all requirements; evaluation frontrunner vs unnamed competitors
- Novara impressed leadership with new capabilities for oversight – e.g., QR codes for tracking fire extinguisher, first aid equipment inspections

SCOOP

Buffalo Rock evaluated Novara (as KPA) and two other unnamed vendors to replace "stagnant" Safety Reports. Novara was their top choice, and decision-maker Braxton McCaleb, Executive Director of Fleet, Safety, Security, and Environmental, was poised to sign the contract. Then, competing priorities – primarily the opening of two new locations – emerged. He decided to put the migration on hold until he and his team had more bandwidth to make it successful. Safety Reports was deemed to be "good enough" for the time being; Braxton said bringing in Novara could be a 2027 goal with planning recommencing in Q3/Q4 2026. He said Novara met all of their requirements and more, calling out the QR code equipment tracking as a compelling feature. He also praised Novara's team for their patient, customer-centric approach during the RFP/trial period. Stay in touch and help Braxton develop an implementation plan to re-ignite this deal.

> *"I had agreements in my box. I reviewed them, sent them to legal. It's just the timing wasn't right for us, is what it came down to ... We were going to go with KPA."*

OPPORTUNITY DETAILS

Decision:	Loss	**Interviewee:**	Braxton McCaleb	**Buyer Type:**	Decision-maker
Close Date:	3/12/2025	**Role:**	Executive Director of Fleet, Safety, Security, and Environmental	**Industry:**	Manufacturing
Deal Amount:	$35,640	**Segment:**	Mid-Market	**NAICS code:**	312111

COMPANY PROFILE

Buffalo Rock is an independently-owned Pepsi bottler and distributor based in southeastern U.S., primarily Alabama. They have 2,100 employees across 18 locations, including a manufacturing site and 14 franchises. Interviewee Braxton McCaleb is the Executive Director of Fleet, Safety, Security, and Environmental.

VISION FOR CHANGE

Pain: Limited use cases, product stagnation, multiple acquisitions pushed Buffalo Rock to consider alternatives to incumbent

Buffalo Rock had been using Align Technologies' Safety Reports solution for incident reporting for around eight years. They were concerned the solution had stagnated, and that the company kept getting acquired. However, Braxton noted that the solution was "pretty good" and was cost-effective, so the pain was not severe.

> *" ... what we had currently, the company we had been using and still are today, we felt like the product had got stagnant and stale, and we're looking at others to utilize."*
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> *" ... this company has been bought about three times. It is concerning. It's called Align technologies. And one of the software platforms underneath them is called Safety Reports. And so we use it for incident investigations."*
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> *"It's not the best, it's not the end-all solution, but it does a pretty good job for what it is. And it's fairly cost-ease from that standpoint, compared to some of the others."*

Vision: Unified system for incident investigations, reporting, safety data management, and compliance tracking

Buffalo Rock wanted to replace their incumbent incident reporting solution with a more powerful safety management platform. Important criteria included: multi-location access with hierarchical data visibility while maintaining data silos, automated data delivery via email without manual system login, ability to generate graphs and tables for metrics like costs, injuries, comp claims, and near misses, ability to handle multiple simultaneous users, form customization, asset number tracking (fleet and forklift), support for multiple incident types, and user access for multiple roles.

> *"We had had some conversations internally about looking at a different platform. From incident investigations, reporting, safety data management systems, forklift ... Not forklift, fire extinguisher tracking compliance, all in one suite."*
>
> *"Of course, the capability to have multiple people to gain access to the system in different regions and locations. You have four or five locations inside a region ... Gulf Coast, Pensacola, Florida, Panama City, Mobile, those on the Gulf make up a Gulf region. You've got people inside each one of those that need*

access to it and put information in. But it needs to be for one of those three cities and then roll up to a Gulf region, then roll up to corporate. So, multiple layers of reporters, but also multiple layers of being able to see that data in silo to whoever's doing really good, or really bad. Or what type of incident. So we needed all that type of information, be able to push data."

"It's one of the most important things in my world, is to be able to take data and not have to log into a software or a platform and mine the data. Don't mind having it get set up or have it a widget setting in there, but I need it pushed to my email on a daily, weekly, quarterly, monthly basis on what information I need to regurgitate to someone else. Whether that be cost outlay because of auto instance injury, comp, number of near misses. All that is very important. That's what we were looking for. And also be able to generate graphs and tables from that standpoint."

" ... be able to withstand a lot of people in the system at one time looking at things, or just not a lot."

"And the capability to make changes to the software as we see needed ... like, 'Hey, you know, this question, we need to change it a little bit.' The capability to not skip questions ... You get to the end and it lets you move on. We didn't want that. It's like, 'Hey, Steve, you missed these two questions. You've got to put information in there.'"

"But then also, all of our fleet and forklift equipment has an asset number and being able to put in there the asset number. That way we can go look in some of our other databases and know, 'Well, that's that unit, it's this old.' We know what the damage is saying is ... We can even think about how much cost it's going to cost to repair some of the damage to it. Or even say, 'Well, that forklift unit is 11 years old and it's got $5,000 worth of repair off that number.' Well, we may not spend that much. We may just say, 'Hey, we're going to remove that from our forklift fleet and we'll replace it with one that's newer.' Of course, name, date of birth, date of hire, position, that type of stuff. You know, we're looking for that as well."

"And we have to use it in a couple different ways, because we have employees that may get injured, but then we're also delivering product in a vehicle. So we have auto incidents. And then we also have a lot of forklifts. I have to have the capability to ... 'Is it an incident investigation involved with a person or an event? Is it auto-related or is it forklift-related?' So at any given time, I may get an incident investigation five hours from here and it could be any of those three.

"And, you know, supervisor, manager, director, executive director, safety coordinator, safety manager, safety director ... Those are likes of the people that we have to have trained and have access to this software."

Internal Readiness: Buffalo Rock opening two new distribution facilities, remodelling others; this is current priority; could revisit for 2027

Braxton was ready to sign with Novara when other competing priorities – primarily the opening of two new locations – emerged. Although Novara was his top choice to replace Align Technologies, he decided to put the project on pause. Things will be quieter next year, he thinks, and Buffalo Rock could begin planning again in Q3/Q4 2026 for a 2027 rollout.

"To be quite honest, we built a 300,000 square foot distribution center down on the Gulf Coast, down in Florida. Then we built a smaller, drop and hook facility, distribution facility up in the northern part of Alabama. And then we also were doing some retrofitting and different things in some other facilities that were going to be impacted by all this. And so my team got sucked into a lot of that. And we just had to pause and say, 'Hey, this is not the right time to do this.'"

"We did a couple remodels. But so what happens is you got a security, we need new cameras, new access controls, safety. You're looking at needing fire extinguishers and training within that new facility and some new machinery in some of these facilities. So lockout, tag out procedures ... All the things that you probably don't think about goes into new facilities that ... And fleet. We had to change some of our fleet models. We had to buy and rent forklifts and lease. And so we ... Lots of planning, lots of financing. All that just sucked up our time. And we had something that worked and we could live with. And we're currently still living with that."

"It's not even up and running yet. It will be in about two months. So we're still impacted by that one facility getting up running a hundred percent. It's going to be this summer before we can start walking away from that facility. That's it. We're just busy. We're just not ready to get into that."

"And long-term, we may revisit that down the road. I don't have it as an initiative or goal this year, but as we start looking into really setting down into Q3, Q4 and thinking about '27, is that something we will revisit? Because I don't think we'll be quite as busy, infrastructure-wise. Even this year, we've got a lot of infrastructure projects that we're doing. And even, like I mentioned, the one that's 350,000 square feet, we still have new technology and proprietary, not to us, but it is ... how the product is picked and moved and put into our vehicles and go to the market."

DECISION PROCESS

Buffalo Rock Company issued an RFP to replace incumbent Align Technologies (Product: Safety Reports). They looked at Novara (then KPA) and "a couple others" that the interviewee did not name. Novara was the preferred solution, and the deal was at the contract phase before Buffalo Rock put it on hold due to competing internal priorities. Interviewee Braxton McCaleb is the decision-maker and budget holder. The evaluation included four members of his team, and was led by his safety director. They may revisit in 2027 and begin planning again in Q3/Q4 2026 as things become quieter.

SALES|MARKETING|PRICING

Paused on signing Novara contract; did not want to begin incurring fees without internal resources in place to support migration

Knowing that they were not ready internally to undertake a significant software migration, Braxton was unwilling to sign the Novara contract and thus begin incurring fees immediately.

"I had agreements and had them sent to legal. It's just the concern was once we signed that agreement, and needing to start using the product, we're paying a monthly fee for that product. And we wouldn't be using it enough to return on investment at that time frame."

National Safety Council conference was site of first introduction to Novara (then KPA); impressed with their software

"A year and a half ago, I was introduced to them at NSC conference, National Safety Council conference. That's where I first had interactions with them. And my safety director and I were there. Big conference, of course, seminars, different things, but huge exhibitor conference as well."

"And so we talked a bunch while we were there and really liked what KPA had to offer on the software side. And so we had started having discussions with them."

Initial Demo (at NSC Conference): Liked Novara; lots of pre-developed components to "play with"; saw how software was used by other companies

" ... did a trial of the dashboard software, whatever. You're looking at a lot of the components that were already developed either for other companies ... or what they had is, I guess, off-the-shelf material that was available for us to look at and play with."

"We did like the software."

Praised Novara's team for patient, customer-centric approach during RFP and trial period

Braxton spoke highly of the Novara rep who supported Buffalo Rock during their RFP and trial. They were patient, engaged, and extended the trial on request.

"Anything we asked from the team that was supporting us during the RFP and the trial usage was good."

"Customer service was great. We had a young lady that really worked with us a lot, and she and a couple of the developers, and she was very patient with us. We strung along the end of decision-making for about a quarter. And I eventually had to tell her, I was like, 'I'm so sorry. You know, we were really there.' I had agreements in my box. I reviewed them, sent them to legal. It just the timing wasn't right for us, is what it came down to. So we were going to go with KPA."

"They did a great job in engaging us and taking us through the RFP, letting us use the product ... Even where we were utilizing like a test model and playing around in it. And they said, 'Hey, you got this much time frame.' And we went back and said, 'Hey, can we have some more time?' They did. They checked in with us a lot and they were very patient. And even at the end, it's like I told them what was wrong and they went up several levels trying to get us to do it. And I said, 'We just can't.' And they were understandable by it. Said, 'Right now we're just too busy internally.' So they were super patient with us, customer-intrinsic, and I applaud them for that."

Initially felt Novara's cost per seat was "a little high" but this did not prevent Buffalo Rock from moving to contract phase; concluded overall price was "fine"

> *"The cost was a little high for the per seat, that we felt like from that standpoint. So if you and I both, you worked, Steve, you worked for Buffalo Rock and I did, and we needed access to it. The cost was a little high, I think, from that thought process."*
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> *"Like I said, I had agreement sitting on my desk that legal had reviewed. Cost was, we were fine with the cost."*

Safety Reports was cost-effective

> *" ... it's fairly cost-ease from that standpoint, compared to some of the others."*

Previous Decision (8yrs ago): Looked at Enablon, Avetta, [inaudible] before selecting Align based on price

> *"Enablon, Avetta ... I think it's [Bear Risk // Vare Risk 00:13:34] or something like that solution. Some of the bigger ones that's been around a long time. Cost was extremely expensive and that was not what I was looking for."*

PRODUCT

Incumbent solution for incident reporting (Safety Reports by Align Technologies) "not the best" overall, but good enough for now

Buffalo Rock was using Safety Reports for incident investigations (employee injury, auto, forklift). Despite some challenges and limitations, it was meeting this use case with a simple, app-based solution that worked. Replacing it was desirable, but not a top priority compared to Buffalo Rock's big infrastructure projects.

> *"We have to use it in a couple different ways, because we have employees that may get injured, but then we're also delivering product in a vehicle. So we have auto incidents. And then we also have a lot of forklifts. I have to have the capability to ... 'Is it an incident investigation involved with a person or an event? Is it auto-related or is it forklift-related?' So at any given time, I may get an incident investigation five hours from here and it could be any of those three. Their software up front was pretty simple to use and pretty straightforward for those that needed it."*
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> *" ... it's app, it's app-based, it's desktop-based, it's Android-friendly. It's all the things you've got to have nowadays. It's a fairly simple software, but it's got backend solutions of tracking and data and things like that, that I can see."*
>
> *" ... we had something that worked and we could live with. And we're currently still living with that."*
>
> *"It's not the best, it's not the end-all solution, but it does a pretty good job for what it is."*

Really liked Novara solution; met all requirements; evaluation frontrunner vs unnamed competitors

Braxton and his team liked Novara's platform the best out of the options they evaluated (he declined to name the other vendors). It met all their requirements, or could be customized to meet those needs.

> *"I will commend them, with KPA and that technology and the software we were looking at. Everything that we threw at it and was wanting to do with it, it was capable to do. Some of it was already developed and some of it, their backend team was working with us to do."*
>
> *"KPA was a frontrunner. We looked at a couple others, and we just liked KPA's platform and dashboard better."*
>
> *" ... we were going to go with KPA."*

Novara impressed leadership with new capabilities for oversight – e.g., QR codes for tracking fire extinguisher, first aid equipment inspections

Braxton said Novara had capabilities that encouraged them to think bigger. For example, his team liked the QR code-enabled equipment tracking, which would be more accurate and offer more visibility than the current manual approach.

Note: "Pencil whipping" (interviewee quote) is the act of signing off on, approving, or documenting completion of tasks, inspections, or reports without actually performing the work.

> *"It gave us capability to do things that we had never thought about. Say, for example, fire extinguishers. You've got multiple in a facility. It got to the point we were talking about having QR codes placed on every one of them. That way, whoever checked those each month, they scanned it, it went into a database, and we can see if there was 30 out of 30, whether they would check. Same thing for AEDs and defibrillators in first aid cabinets. Making sure that somebody was actually looking at those every month. There's supposed to be a tag on every one of those, but you can pencil whip that. But if you scan a QR code for each one of those and it updated ... We like that."*

Align Technologies made improvements to their Safety Reports solution

Buffalo Rock almost walked away from Align Technologies' "stagnant and stale" Safety Reports platform. However, when things got busy, they asked this vendor if there had been any improvements. The platform had improved somewhat. This reinforced Braxton's assessment that the incumbent, although "not the best," was not in dire need of replacement.

> *"We also went back and looked at our current provider and said, 'Hey, Is there certain things you can do that you used to not be able to do?' Because it's always, technology and software and IT is always evolving. What you couldn't do two years ago, even with the number of letters and fonts in a box and things, well, the software had now updated where you could do some of that. Or uploading pictures was really clunky. Well, then it got better. Their technology got better."*

" ... the incident reporting tool at first was pretty simplistic. And we've had them retool it a couple times for us to get more data-centric and crisper data."

Already using KPA software (RMC) for training purposes; provided by insurance broker; customizable

Buffalo Rock's team already has access to "a lot" of policies, procedures, and other training resources via RMC.

"However, I do want to let you know we have an insurance broker and they run in the insurance world, the risk and safety world. And we have access to a platform that is KPA-based, and my team does use that. And so it's got a lot of, say, policies, procedures. You're looking for something around how to train your employees in emergency evacuation planning, or you need just a document. Well, they've got all this different materials you can take off that site because of what they do, and then make it your own within that company. And so I do use KPA software today. It's just through our insurance broker. We have access to that because of what we pay from a premium standpoint. There are certain things that we have access to and that's one of their databases. They share that with their customers because that's what they do."

SERVICES|CX|CUSTOMER SUCCESS

Concerned about ability to successfully launch Novara across Buffalo Rock based on internal team bandwidth

Implementing Novara began "falling down the pecking order of priorities" after two major infrastructure projects began (see Internal Readiness). This impacted Braxton and his team's availability, and he was hesitant to move forward. Implementation was discussed briefly during the evaluation; showing how Novara can help support this will be key when re-engaging.

"We talked a little bit about implementation ... It's just, I knew my team and everybody within the organization would struggle heavily. And I was not willing to put my name on that and it'd be something where it was like, 'Yeah, we got it, but we don't really understand it or we're just not doing a good job dealing with it.'"

"We had a lot going on internally inside our company from an infrastructure construction standpoint, just to be honest, and just the day-to-day activities that we were trying to get done. And this just started falling down the pecking order of priorities for us to get done. And we tried a couple times looking at it and saying, 'Hey, do we want to try to do this? Or do we just got too much going on internally, infrastructure-wise?'"

" ... And maybe, KPA could have helped out a little bit with that. But again, if I'm going to do something and have my name on it and my team's name on it ... and I'm going to ask the entire organization to utilize this type of software and data, I want to be able to have involvement, make sure the training is right - that's online or in person. And to be able to support them when I say, 'Hey guys, we're going to pull this plug on this one, put this new one in.'"

"That was the big piece. We just didn't feel comfortable with that from that standpoint."

" ... get training done, and all that. Our team, my team just didn't have time. We just ran out of runway, to be honest."

ACTIONS AND OPPORTUNITIES

Topic	Description
Likely to revisit Novara – Stay in touch	Likely to revisit KPA/Novara once major projects stabilize. No initiative in 2026; potential reassessment in late 2026 planning for 2027. Stay in touch and work to co-develop an implementation plan.

Recording: https://app.box.com/s/rebgen6yj8ixz3rsr0a2r2qxwnm2uovj

TRANSCRIPT

IcebergIQ
Scribbling. Okay, great. So once again, thanks so much Braxton for taking the time to speak with me. As mentioned, we're going to have a conversation about your recent experience with Novara. Before we do that though, I would love to learn a little bit more about your organization, Buffalo Rock.

Braxton
Yes, sure. Buffalo Rock is an independently owned Pepsi bottler and distributor here in the Southeast. It's primarily, I would say, 90% of the state of Alabama. We have a few pockets that other, other smaller franchise distributors on Panhandle Florida take from the Mississippi line all the way over on the other side of Panama City, kind of halfway between Panama City and Tallahassee, Florida. And then south of Atlanta, Newnan, Georgia, Columbus, Georgia, and Albany, Georgia. So if you're looking at a map of Georgia, it's kind of that central, southwest part of it. We have 2,100 employees.

We bottle Pepsi and we actually distribute it. So we have a manufacturing site that runs continuously about eight lines and we ... Anything that's under the Pepsi umbrella, we bottle and distribute. We bottle and distribute some Dr. Pepper products. And then we have a couple proprietary lines that we bottle as well. We have roughly 14 franchise locations in all, in roughly 18 buildings that house Buffalo Rock employees and do different things from that standpoint. I've been here eight years, roughly eight years.

My oversight is all things fleet. And what I mean by that is, if it has wheels on it, it pretty much falls underneath my purview – whether we purchase, lease, or rent. And that's going to be on the highway side, tractors and trailers and box trucks and cars, small fleet things you and I would get into for sales teams, vending-type thing, and then material handling equipment, forklifts. And a lot of other things are there. Then the other side of it, my oversight is everything occupational safety, environmental –

think EPA – and then lastly, physical security, which is going to be access control, cameras, workplace safety, that type of thing.

So I have four different silos that I support within the company. My official title is Executive Director of Fleet, Safety, Security, Environmental. I know that's a lot, but I rattled off. It's a big old title. I do have a team that supports each one of those functions. A couple of them are a director role, and then I have one that is kind of corporate-centric, because we have a large manufacturing facility.

Hold on. Let me just text, this is one of the guys that works for me now ... Or I don't like to say that works for me, that I support. And I'm just gonna tell him I'll call him back. "I'll call you back later."

IcebergIQ
That's a great summary.

Braxton
Yeah. Sorry about that. Let me ...

IcebergIQ
Yeah.

Braxton
So anyway, I have a team to kind of ... Each one of those functions kind of supports underneath it from that standpoint. I mean, team. It's a skeleton team. We get a lot done with a small group, but that's Buffalo Rock. We've been around 120 plus years, and we're family-owned and operated. Fourth generation. There's not anybody in the fifth, but the sixth generation is actually the grandson. The grandson of the owner is ... has just joined us in the last two years from college. So it's pretty cool.

IcebergIQ
Oh, yeah. That's a great summary, too. Thank you very much for sharing that. Okay. And just so you know, this is the first, actually, the first interview we have done with this new client, so ...

Braxton
Oh, goodness.

IcebergIQ
Yeah, so. So you're the bit of the guinea pig. Go easy on me. And if I ask, you know, some questions-

Braxton
Same here. Same here. I will tell you, you're ... Are you Eastern or Central time?

IcebergIQ
Eastern.

Braxton
Okay. At 2:30 I do have a hard stop. That's right. Let's say you're ... Yeah, 1 0, you're 2:07 there. You're Eastern. You're ahead of me. I do have a ... I do have a hard stop at 2:30.

IcebergIQ
I gotcha. Okay. I'll be respectful of that. So why don't we-

Braxton
It's my boss. It's my boss.

IcebergIQ
Yeah.

Braxton
Yeah, I've been gone for three days. He's like, "We've got to connect. You got a list, I got a list."

IcebergIQ
Gotcha. Well, I appreciate you squeezing me in very much. Maybe to talk a little bit now about Novara, maybe to start at the beginning, what was going on at the organization that led you to talk to them or perhaps others about what they do, environmental health and safety, services platform software.

Braxton
Alright, let me back up. So has Novara ... Did they acquire KPA?

IcebergIQ
Other way ... Well, KPA spun off, or actually they bought Novara. It was the health and safety part of the business and they've spun that off into a separate offering.

Braxton
Yeah. My interactions has been on the health and safety side with, I assume, KPA, not Novara. So I just-

IcebergIQ
Yeah. Same company.

Braxton
Okay. Alright. A year and a half ago, I was introduced to them at NSC conference, National Safety Council conference. That's where I first had interactions with them. And my safety director and I were there. Big conference, of course, seminars, different things, but huge exhibitor conference as well. And we had had some conversations internally about looking at a different platform. From incident investigations, reporting, safety data management systems, forklift ... Not forklift, fire extinguisher tracking compliance, all in one suite. Because what we had currently, the company we had been using and still are today, we felt like the product had got stagnant and stale, and we're looking at others to utilize.

And so we talked a bunch while we were there and really liked what KPA had to offer on the software side. And so we had started having discussions with them. Some of their sales team, that first group of people did a trial of the dashboard software, whatever. You're looking at a lot of the components that were already developed either for other companies ... or what they had is, I guess, off-the-shelf material that was available for us to look at and play with.

We did like the software. The cost was a little high for the per seat, that we felt like from that standpoint. So if you and I both, you worked, Steve, you worked for Buffalo Rock and I did, and we needed access to it. The cost was a little high, I think, from that thought process. Anything we asked from the team that was supporting us during the RFP and the trial usage was good. But to be honest, it got called up into a couple of things. We had a lot going on internally inside our company from an infrastructure construction standpoint, just to be honest, and just the day-to-day activities that we were trying to get done. And this just started falling down the pecking order of priorities for us to get done. And we tried a couple times looking at it and saying, "Hey, do we want to try to do this? Or do we just got too much going on internally, infrastructure-wise?" To be quite honest, we built a 300,000 square foot distribution center down on the Gulf Coast, down in Florida.

Then we built a smaller, drop and hook facility, distribution facility up in the northern part of Alabama. And then we also were doing some retrofitting and different things in some other facilities that were going to be impacted by all this. And so my team got sucked into a lot of that. And we just had to pause and say, "Hey, this is not the right time to do this." We also went back and looked at our current provider and said, "Hey, Is there certain things you can do that you used to not be able to do?" Because it's always, technology and software and IT is always evolving. What you couldn't do two years ago, even with the number of letters and fonts in a box and things, well, the software had now updated where you could do some of that. Or uploading pictures was really clunky. Well, then it got better. Their technology got better.

I will commend them, with KPA and that technology and the software we were looking at. Everything that we threw at it and was wanting to do with it, it was capable to do. Some of it was already developed and some of it, their backend team was working with us to do. And the intent was to probably start using that software, sign an agreement, whatever that time frame was, Steve, and jump in and start it. But it was just a bad time for us to start looking into that and doing it, to be honest. And so we just had to shelve it as a goal from that standpoint.

However, I do want to let you know we have an insurance broker and they run in the insurance world, the risk and safety world. And we have access to a platform that is KPA-based, and my team does use that. And so it's got a lot of, say, policies, procedures. You're looking for something around how to train your employees in emergency evacuation planning, or you need just a document. Well, they've got all this different materials you can take off that site because of what they do, and then make it your own within that company. And so I do use KPA software today. It's just through our insurance broker. We have access to that because of what we pay from a premium standpoint. There are certain things that

we have access to and that's one of their databases. They share that with their customers because that's what they do.

So that's the initial introduction and where we were involved with KPA. There was one, two, three, four on my side that was part of that project in working with KPA. My safety director was the lead. I was right beside him. Then I had two other people working with the project, as well. So that's in a nutshell where we were. It just was really bad timing for us to probably ... We'd probably be a customer today, to be honest. And I'm not saying I wouldn't be long-term. It's just we've got to spend time, think about it, and maybe we introduce and have conversations again sometime in the future. Probably not this year. We've got a lot of goals and initiatives, but it's one of mine to probably, really look at that next year, just to be honest.

IcebergIQ
Okay. There's a lot-

Braxton
I know I talk a lot. Sorry.

IcebergIQ
No, no, no. That was great. And you saved me from asking a lot of questions, but I want to unpack a little bit of that. So the incumbent solution, what is that? Do you mind me asking?

Braxton
No, I don't mind you asking. It's a smaller company. Years ago when I came to Buffalo Rock about eight years ago, our current incident investigation process was just, quite frankly, horrid. And I started looking at vendors and solutions that were, I would say, middle of the pack player. Not your larger ones, let's say, Enablon, Avetta. KPA, I don't think was around then. I'm trying to historically think about those that were around eight years ago, some of the bigger ones that were out there. And I'm familiar with the Enablon, Avetta, [Bear Risk 00:13:34] or something like that solution. Some of the bigger ones that's been around a long time. Cost was extremely expensive and that was not what I was looking for. And so this company or who we went with has been bought about three times. It is concerning. It's called Align technologies. And one of the software platforms underneath them is called safety Reports. And so we use it for incident investigations.

And we have to use it in a couple different ways, because we have employees that may get injured, but then we're also delivering product in a vehicle. So we have auto incidents. And then we also have a lot of forklifts. I have to have the capability to ... "Is it an incident investigation involved with a person or an event? Is it auto-related or is it forklift-related?" So at any given time, I may get an incident investigation five hours from here and it could be any of those three. Their software up front was pretty simple to use and pretty straightforward for those that needed it.

And, you know, supervisor, manager, director, executive director, safety coordinator, safety manager, safety director ... Those are likes of the people that we have to have trained and have access to this

software. A frontline employee driver, they're not going to do the incident investigation. Somebody at least a level supervisor above that's had training on 5Y. And how to do an incident investigation is going to have access to this database or this software. And it's app, it's app-based, it's desktop-based, it's Android-friendly. It's all the things you've got to have nowadays. It's a fairly simple software, but it's got backend solutions of tracking and data and things like that, that I can see.

But the incident reporting tool at first was pretty simplistic. And we've had them retool it a couple times for us to get more data-centric and crisper data. It's not the best, it's not the end-all solution, but it does a pretty good job for what it is. And it's fairly cost-ease from that standpoint, compared to some of the others. Again, we almost walked away from them last year, and I'm not saying we won't. Eventually we just gotta find the right time and the time to do so. So that's some of the things we were looking at.

IcebergIQ
Okay, and I take it you went to this NSC conference with the notion that you wanted to find, or have discussions, or source people that could respond to replacing that system. You said there were internal discussions for a different system. Did you have, as you went through that process of looking at different ... did you have a list of criteria or things that you were, that you needed? You mentioned an RFP. So that was-

Braxton
Yeah. Of course, the capability to have multiple people to gain access to the system in different regions and locations. You have four or five locations inside a region. Just think about down the Gulf Coast, Pensacola, Florida, Panama City, Mobile, that type of thing. Right on the ... Those on the Gulf make up a Gulf region. You've got people inside each one of those that need access to it and put information in. But it needs to be for one of those three cities and then roll up to a Gulf region, then roll up to corporate. So multiple layers of reporters, but also multiple layers of being able to see that data in silo to whoever's doing really good, or really bad. Or what type of incident. So we needed all that type of information, be able to push data. It's one of the most important things in my world, is to be able to take data and not have to log into a software or a platform and mine the data. Don't mind having it get set up or have it a widget setting in there, but I need it pushed to my email on a daily, weekly, quarterly, monthly basis on what information I need to regurgitate to someone else. Whether that be cost outlay because of auto instance injury, comp, number of near misses. All that is very important. That's what we were looking for. And also be able to generate graphs and tables from that standpoint.

And be able to withstand a lot of people in the system at one time looking at things, or just not a lot. But also the cost component of it is, that it's either a package annually dependent on the number of users. Say you're between 150 and 200, you're gonna pay this amount. Or per seat usage. Understand that everyone has to make money. That's the reason for it. So those were some of the things we were looking at. And the capability to make changes to the software as we see needed. As we see things is like, "Hey, you know, this question, we need to change it a little bit." The capability to not skip questions, or N/A them, or "Unknown." Did not like that. Did not want that. Or get to a question and

you skip it. You get to the end and it lets you move on. We didn't want that. It's like, "Hey, Steve, you missed these two questions. You've got to put information in there."

But then also, all of our fleet and forklift equipment has an asset number and being able to put in there the asset number. That way we can go look in some of our other databases and know, "Well, that's that unit, it's this old." We know what the damage is saying is ... We can even think about how much cost it's going to cost to repair some of the damage to it. Or even say, "Well, that forklift unit is 11 years old and it's got $5,000 worth of repair off that number." Well, we may not spend that much. We may just say, "Hey, we're going to remove that from our forklift fleet and we'll replace it with one that's newer." Or jockey some stuff around, or maybe they've got a spare at that facility. We're just not going to, we're not going to repair it. So those are some of the things with it that's there. Of course, name, date of birth, data hire, position, that type of stuff. You know, we're looking for that as well.

IcebergIQ
Okay. And I want to be mindful of the time here. I do have a few things to get through. We have seven minutes. So if I start talking really fast-

Braxton
I'll try to keep my answers short.

IcebergIQ
I want to get to the decision. So you went through a process. You sent an RFP out. I take it, to multiple vendors. Tell me about your assessment. What happened at the end? Who did you end up selecting? I know you didn't actually put something into place, but is there a-?

Braxton
KPA was a frontrunner. We looked at a couple others, and we just like KPA's platform and dashboard better. It gave us capability to do things that we had never thought about. Say, for example, fire extinguishers. You've got multiple in a facility. It got to the point we were talking about having QR codes placed on every one of them. That way, whoever checked those each month, they scanned it, it went into a database, and we can see if there was 30 out of 30, whether they would check. Same thing for AEDs and defibrillators in first aid cabinets. Making sure that somebody was actually looking at those, every month. There's supposed to be a tag on every one of those, but you can pencil whip that. But if you scan a QR code for each one of those and it updated ... We like that.

Customer service was great. We had a young lady that really worked with us a lot, and she and a couple of the developers, and she was very patient with us. We strung along the end of decision-making for about a quarter. And I eventually had to tell her, I was like, "I'm so sorry. You know, we were really there." I had agreements in my box. I reviewed them, sent them to legal. It just the timing wasn't right for us, is what it came down to. So we were going to go with KPA.

IcebergIQ

When you say the timing wasn't right to you, was that because there was on your side going to be a heavy lift to get things implemented or-

Braxton
Yeah, my team was just heavily involved in not only just the day-to-day aspects of our jobs, but again, we built a new facility last year. It was 350,000 square feet. We've did another one that was under 100,000. We did a couple remodels. But so what happens is you got a security, we need new cameras, new access controls, safety. You're looking at needing fire extinguishers and training within that new facility and some new machinery in some of these facilities. So lockout, tag out procedures ... All the things that you probably don't think about goes into new facilities that ... And fleet. We had to change some of our fleet models. We had to buy and rent forklifts and lease. And so we ... Lots of planning, lots of financing. All that just sucked up our time. And we had something that worked and we could live with. And we're currently still living with that.

Again, I had agreements and had them sent to legal. It's just the concern was once we signed that agreement, and needing to start using the product, we're paying a monthly fee for that product. And we wouldn't be using it enough to return on investment at that time frame. So what I'm saying is sign it, get training done, and all that. Our team, my team just didn't have time. We just ran out of runway, to be honest.

IcebergIQ
Okay. What would have made the difference here, in you going forward with this? Would it have been, I don't know, a lower cost? Would it have been less involvement from your team in terms of getting it up and running? Would it have been ... And I guess, and what would make it the right time when you go back to revisit this?

Braxton
More than just our team just not having enough time. And maybe, KPA could have helped out a little bit with that. But again, if I'm going to do something and have my name on it and my team's name on it ... and I'm going to ask the entire organization to utilize this type of software and data, I want to be able to have involvement, make sure the training is right – that's online or in person. And to be able to support them when I say, "Hey guys, we're going to pull this plug on this one, put this new one in."

That was the big piece. We just didn't feel comfortable with that from that standpoint. And long-term, we may revisit that down the road. I don't have it as an initiative or goal this year, but as we start looking into really setting down into Q3, Q4 and thinking about '27, is that something we will revisit? Because I don't think we'll be quite as busy, infrastructure-wise. Even this year, we've got a lot of infrastructure projects that we're doing. And even, like I mentioned, the one that's 350,000 square feet, we still have new technology and proprietary, not to us, but it is ... how the product is picked and moved and put into our vehicles and go to the market.

It's not even up and running yet. It will be in about two months. So we're still impacted by that one facility getting up running a hundred percent. It's going to be this summer before we can start walking away from that facility. That's it. We're just busy. We're just not ready to get into that.

IcebergIQ
Did you get down as far with them as to look at an onboarding or implementation plan, as to what that would involve?

Braxton
We talked a little bit about implementation. Like I said, I had agreement sitting on my desk that legal had reviewed. Cost was, we were fine with the cost. It's just, I knew my team and everybody within the organization would struggle heavily. And I was not willing to put my name on that and it'd be something where it was like, "Yeah, we got it, but we don't really understand it or we're just not doing a good job dealing with it."

IcebergIQ
Okay. And we're timing out, so I want to ask you. Just based on your entire experience in terms of dealing with the sales team, looking at the product and its capabilities, what advice would you have for them? Is there something you'd want to see on the roadmap? Is there something you think their teams could be doing a little bit differently in terms of how they engage with their clients? What would you want to share with them?

Braxton
I would share with them, they did a great job in engaging us and taking us through the RFP, letting us use the product ... Even where we were utilizing like a test model and playing around in it. And they said, "Hey, you got this much time frame." And we went back and said, "Hey, can we have some more time?" They did. They checked in with us a lot and they were very patient. And even at the end, it's like I told them what was wrong and they went up several levels trying to get us to do it. And I said, "We just can't." And they were understandable by it. Said, "Right now we're just too busy internally." So they were super patient with us, customer-intrinsic, and I applaud them for that.

IcebergIQ
Awesome. Alright. And you were the ultimate decision-maker here?

Braxton
I am.

IcebergIQ
Okay, awesome. Great. Thank you so much for your time. I really wish we had more time to spend, but I know you've got to go off to your other call. I appreciate the time you did spend with me.

Braxton
Thank you, Steve. Appreciate it.

IcebergIQ
Alright, have a great weekend. Bye.